



fee—the Heart of Sharjah offers all this and more.

Beyond contemporary art, Sharjah's cultural heritage extends to its archaeological sites and historical landmarks as well. The planned UNESCO World Heritage Site at Mleiha has a remarkable collection of fossils, dating back around 90 million years, providing information on the natural history of the Arabian Peninsula. A visit to the Mleiha Archaeological Centre (ticket price 25 AED) reveals artefacts from the Stone Age to the pre-Islamic era.

Mleiha is more than simply a collection of artefacts. Surrounded with rolling red sand dunes, it is Sharjah's top desert adventure destination. Book yourself a dune bashing experience followed by dinner under the stars at one of the camps for 175-200 AED (₹4,000-4,700).

If it's a bit of greenery you seek, head to Al Noor Island (ticket price 50 AED). Home to a butterfly house, a literature pavilion and a 250-year-old olive tree, it also has waterbod-

1. See different varieties of butterflies at Butterfly House on Al Noor Island

2. Explore Heart of Sharjah with its art galleries, museums and local souks

3. The annual Sharjah Light Festival is a treat for locals and tourists alike

ies, a trampoline pathway, and 300-million-year-old fossil rocks from Brazil. But the highlight is Butterfly House (35 AED, or around ₹800) that houses a variety of butterfly species.

Continuing with your exploration of the natural world, visit the Sharjah Safari (120 AED, or about ₹3,000)—supposedly the largest safari in the world outside Africa. It is spread over eight sq. kms. inside the Al Bardi reserve, around 55 km from Sharjah city. This open-air zoo has different African zones where varied wildlife roam freely, except for the enclosures where lions, elephants, and crocodiles are kept.

There is a lot more that the Emirate offers from Hanging Gardens to the Khor Kalba Mangrove Center. Depending upon what you are looking for, Sharjah welcomes you to explore its multifaceted layers. **BT**

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